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A psychotherapist's lived experience in-session with an asylum seeker and translator: An autoethnographic case study

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ABSTRACT

Featured in this article is a psychotherapy case study recounted from the lived experience of the psychotherapist working with an asylum seeker from Afghanistan, with the help of a translator. The method applied is an aesthetic inquiry adapted from Autoethnography which engages the practitioner as the researcher who enters the 'field' of the therapy situation. The reflexive writing of the case story, which is integral to the method, sets off a heuristic process, integrating research and practice. Reading this case study, one may grasp the nuances and the atmosphere of an otherwise linguistically challenging therapeutic situation. The story and Gestalt therapy theory are weaved together, which makes palpable, intangible aspects of the therapeutic process.

Die gelebte Erfahrung eines Psychotherapeuten in einer Sitzung mit einem Asylbewerber und Übersetzer: Eine autoethnografische Fallstudie

ABSTRAKT

In diesem Artikel wird eine Psychotherapie-Fallstudie vorgestellt, die aus der gelebten Erfahrung eines Psychotherapeuten erzählt wird, der mit Hilfe eines Übersetzers mit einem Asylbewerber aus Afghanistan arbeitet. Die angewandte Methode ist eine aus der Autoethnographie adaptierte ästhetische Untersuchung, die den Praktiker als den Forscher einbindet, der in das 'Feld' der Therapiesituation eintritt. Das reflexive Schreiben der Fallgeschichte, das integraler Bestandteil der Methode ist, setzt einen heuristischen Prozess in Gang, der Forschung und Praxis integriert. Wenn man diese Fallstudie liest, kann man die Nuancen und die Atmosphäre einer ansonsten sprachlich herausfordernden therapeutischen Situation erfassen. Die Geschichte und die Theorie der Gestalttherapie werden miteinander verwoben, wodurch greifbare, nicht greifbare Aspekte des therapeutischen Prozesses entstehen.

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La experiencia vivida de un Psicoterapeuta En sesión con un Solicitante de Asilo yTraductor: Un Estudio de Caso Autoetnográfico

RESUMEN

Presentado en este artículo es un estudio de caso de psicoterapia relatado a partir de la experiencia vivida del psicoterapeuta que trabaja con un solicitante de asilo de Afganistán, con la ayuda de un traductor. El método aplicado es una investigación estética adaptada de la Autoetnografía que involucra al practicante como el investigador que ingresa al 'campo' de la situación de la terapia. La escritura reflexiva de la historia del caso, que es parte integral del método, desencadena un proceso heurístico, integrando la investigación y la práctica. Al leer este estudio de caso, uno puede comprender los matices y la atmósfera de una situación terapéutica lingüísticamente desafiante. La historia y la teoría de la terapia Gestalt se entrelazan, lo que hace palpables e intangibles aspectos del proceso terapéutico.

L'esperienza vissuta da uno psicoterapeuta nel setting terapeutico con un richiedente asilo e traduttore: un caso di studio autoetnografico

RIASSUNTO

In primo pianotroviamo in questo articolo un casodi studio di psicoterapia che consiste nel racconto dell'esperienza vissuta dallo psicoterapeuta che lavora con un richiedente asilo dall'Afghanistan, con l'aiuto di un traduttore. Il metodo applicato è l'indagine estetica adattata dall'Autoetnografia che coinvolge il professionista come il ricercatore che entra nel 'campo' della situazione terapeutica. La scrittura riflessiva della 'case story', che è parte integrante del metodo, innesca un processo euristico, integrando ricerca e pratica. Leggendo questo caso di studio, si possono cogliere le sfumature e l'atmosfera di una situazione terapeutica altrimenti linguisticamente impegnativa. La storia e la teoria della terapia della Gestalt sono intrecciate insieme, il che rende palpabili gli aspetti intangibili del processo terapeutico.

L'expérience vécue d'un psychothérapeute en session avec un demandeur d'asile et un interprète: une étude de cas auto-ethnographique

ABSTRAIT

Cet article applique une étude de cas qui raconte l'expérience vécue d'un psychothérapeute travaillant avec un demandeur d'asile provenant d'Afghanistan, avec l'aide d'un interprète. La méthode appliquée est une enquête esthétique adaptée par l'auto-ethnographie qui engage le pratiquant en tant que chercheur qui entre dans le domaine de la thérapie. La méthode de réflexion avec laquelle cette étude de cas a été rédigée, engendre un processus heuristique qui intègre la recherche et la pratique. En lisant cette étude de cas, on appréciera les nuances et l'atmosphère des défis linguistiques dans la situation thérapeutique. L'histoire et la théorie de la thérapie Gestalt sont tissées ensemble, et cela rend palpable les aspects intangibles du processus thérapeutique.

Μια βιωμένη εμπειρία ψυχοθεραπευτή εντός θεραπείας με αιτούντα άσυλο και μεταφραστή: Μια αυτοεθνογραφική μελέτη περίπτωσης

ΠΕΡΊΛΗΨΗ
Σε αυτό το άρθρο παρουσιάζεται μια μελέτη περίπτωσης ψυχοθεραπείας που αφηγείται τη βιωμένη εμπειρία του ψυχοθεραπευτή που εργάζεται με έναν αιτούντα άσυλο από το Αφγανιστάν, με τη βοήθεια ενός μεταφραστή. Η μέθοδος που εφαρμόζεται είναι μια αισθητική διερεύνηση προσαρμοσμένη από την Αυτοεθνογραφία που εμπλέκει τον θεραπευτή ως τον ερευνητή που εισέρχεται στο «πεδίο» της θεραπευτικής κατάστασης. Η αντανακλαστική γραφή της μελέτης, η οποία είναι αναπόσπαστο μέρος της μεθόδου, δημιουργεί μια ερμηνευτική διαδικασία, που ενσωματώνει την έρευνα και την πρακτική. Διαβάζοντας αυτήν την μελέτη περίπτωσης, μπορεί κανείς να κατανοήσει τις αποχρώσεις και την ατμόσφαιρα μιας κατά τα άλλα γλωσσικά προκλητικής θεραπευτικής κατάστασης. Η ιστορία και η θεωρία της θεραπείας Γκεστάλτ συνδυάζονται, γεγονός που καθιστά απτές άυλες πτυχές της θεραπευτικής διαδικασίας.

KEYWORDS Autoethnography; psychotherapy case study; psychotherapy process; gestalt therapy

SCHLÜSSELWÖRTER Autoethnographie; Fallbeispiel Psychotherapie; Psychotherapieprozess; Gestalttherapie

PALABRAS CLAVE autoetnografía; estudio de caso de psicoterapia; proceso de psicoterapia; terapia gestalt

PAROLE CHIAVE autoetnografia; caso di studio di psicoterapia; processo di psicoterapia; terapia della gestalt

MOTS-CLÉS auto-ethnographie; étude de cas en psychothérapie; le processus psychothérapeutique; la thérapie Gestalt

ΛΈΞΕΙΣ-ΚΛΕΙΔΙΆ Αυτοεθνογραφία; μελέτη περίπτωσης ψυχοθεραπείας; ψυχοθεραπευτική διαδικασία; θεραπεία Γκεστάλτ

Introduction

Presented here is a psychotherapy case study of a psychotherapist's phenomenological experience of working with a client, an asylum seeker, with the assistance of a translator. Autoethnography is the method applied to this study. While the application of Autoethnography to psychotherapy research exists (Grant, 2010; Jones, 2015; Siddique, 2011; Talbot, 2018), the approach used here, and a recent writing (Chew-Helbig, 2022), is differentiated by 1) applying the method to inquiry into psychotherapy process, 2) defining the therapist as autoethnographer, and 3) defining the therapeutic encounter as the field. The product of Autoethnography is the aesthetic form of writing, a creative non-fiction.

This method promises to help us grasp the non- and pre-verbal nuances, the aesthetic aspect of the therapeutic situation, of the psychotherapy process

and psychopathology that current research paradigms grapple with. Theory and practice are then integrated by weaving in story with theory. Demonstrated here is a possibility, through the method, for therapists to exchange naturalistic in-practice learnings.

Method

Autoethnography, defined in Adams et al. (2015) and Poulos (2021), is a qualitative research method, that delivers a genre of academic writing that is evocative, reflexive, creative and aesthetic. This aesthetic inquiry belongs to a post-modernistic attitude towards research.

The method positions the psychotherapist as autoethnographer. The 'field' is the therapy process of a client being studied. Data is derived from the practitioner's session notes, which are also the field notes. Autoethnography is an observational, data-driven phenomenological method. When used to study a client's psychotherapeutic process from the viewpoint of the practitioner, invaluable phenomenological insights can be obtained. Integral to the process of doing this research is its reflexive writing. We use theory to inquire and explain the nuances of experience, while the story is a mechanism that illustrates how these nuances are sensed and felt (Adams et al., 2015, p. 90). Both theory and story exist symbiotically, and in this article, are presented together.

Actors in this case study are: 1) the client, Ali,[1] who's about 30. He arrived in Vienna from Afghanistan 3 months earlier and was seeking asylum status in Vienna. He was referred to the clinic by social services, having been diagnosed with posttraumatic stress disorder (PTSD). 2) The therapist, who's in her late 40s, is Singaporean and has lived in Austria for more than a decade. She is a Gestalt therapist in private practice, and the narrator of this case study. 3) The translator, Zaya, who is in her early 40s, is Iranian, and was training as a therapist, and was on a student's visa in Vienna.

Case study: 'Undercurrent'

Zaya, the translator for our sessions, was already there when I entered the spacious therapy room of the psychotherapy clinic in Vienna. There is a cardboard file on the coffee table in front of her with its documents spewed out.

It is a chilly autumn morning and the air in the room has not warmed up yet. In the corridor outside the room, are sounds of other colleagues getting started for the day. In about fifteen minutes we expect the client, Ali, to walk in. We look silently through Ali's file. A little bit of preparation can calm nerves. 'Sometimes they don't want to come', says Zaya, who has already translated for many Farsi-speaking clients. Ali is the first client from the asylum seeker group that I am being assigned to. I find support in Zaya's

words. Yes. I can imagine how many who are living in the camps would not like to come for therapy, especially so early in the morning. Then there's Ali who is a man shy of thirty. He has fled his home in Kabul a couple of months before. He is probably one of thousands of asylum seekers now fearing possible deportation. What could possibly motivate him to sit in this room in therapy with two women who are almost a generation older than he is? Putting Ali's intake questionnaires together with the diagnostic reports back into the file, I thank her for being here.

By the time Ali walked in, we were both leaning back on chairs arranged around the little glass coffee table. Ali takes his seat on the empty chair. He keeps his puffed bomber jacket on.

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I have been wary of the prospect of having a translator in the therapy room, concerned about having to form a connection with the client while relying on a go-between, whose presence could potentially feel like a kind of interference. A part of me has lent myself to the opinion of many colleagues who do not want to face this experience. The other part of me is curious about the process.

Ali settles himself down. He has a head of unkempt curly hair, his smile, cherubic. He smiles a lot. Ali and I share a silent smile and a nod. He exchanges some words with Zaya that sound like casual greetings.

> 'Here we are', I start, 'three of us'.
> Zaya translates.

With this first turn, I feel a warmth. Zaya's presence is a support that fills a certain void between me and the client. I'm also painfully aware of how this sensation of being supported feels long-lost. The translator in the session listens intently to every word we say. She echoes the phrases in her mother tongue, a language that is totally foreign to me. She lends herself no voice of her own. I pendulate between feeling thankful and awkward. Am I speaking too quickly? Am I not sufficiently coherent? I shrug off thoughts that I am burdening the translator. I notice myself feeling responsible for everyone else in the room.

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On the phenomenological experience of pathos

Prior to entering the field, the therapist had an expectation of working with a translator in the session, having taken reference from other colleagues. On contact with the field, she was touched by an experience that felt alien to her. Francesetti (2019) describes the experience of being moved beyond our ability to make logic out of the experience, is described as the *pathic*. 'We are seized by the pathic; we do not choose it, we are moved by it; pathic has the same root as

passion and pathology, both happen to us and take us without choice: it is something *to which* we are subject (rather than *of which* we are subject)' (Francesetti, 2019, p. 41). The therapist sensed this suffering, though it was not made explicit at the time of the session. In a phenomenological field, experiences are allowed to emerge, which are not merely subjective reality, but also unique to the moment, ephemeral, co-created, situated, corporeal and dynamic. Even though the pathos described here is felt by, and belongs to the therapist, it belongs to the field of the triad as well.

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The client, Ali, as reflected in his intake documents, is diagnosed with PTSD. He arrived in Austria having bought his way out of Afghanistan by paying human smugglers to take him, along with a group of other Afghani men, on a treacherous passage by land that lasted months. In Austria, he was homed in a remote Austrian village, from which he absconded, ending up in a camp in Vienna. While he awaits getting his asylum status approved in Vienna, he is provided with lodging, a payout of about 800 Euros per month, and a middle high school education. Until Ali's asylum status is approved, he lives with the possibility of being deported back to Afghanistan. Zaya and I are acutely mindful of the immense stress this uncertainty – over and above the other imminent issues – can have, as this is part of the ongoing discourse surrounding all of us who work with asylum seekers.

In these first moments of meeting Ali, I notice myself fighting (and then accepting) within me, a sensation of dread; my limbs feel heavy, my breathing shallow. I sense shifts of fearing not being of use as a therapist for the client and burdening the translator, to fearing feeling the pain of getting to know a client who may go through deportation.

> 'I want to be understood', says Ali, still smiling, when I asked what he would like to have happen for him through our work together. 'I want to achieve things'.
> Zaya translates.
> 'I would like that for myself too, to be understood and to achieve things', I say,
> Zaya translates.
> There's cautious laughter.
> 'I'm wondering, what are the things you wish to achieve?' I ask.
> Zaya translates.
> 'Things. Like I am scared of saying "hello" to Anna'. He replies, and grins; a teenager revealing a crush.
> Zaya translates.
> 'Anna', I smile back.
> Zaya smiles.
> 'Anna', says Ali.

Pre-formation of the contact

The awareness of the ongoing phenomena that emerges from background of the field brings about an opportunity for making contact with the environment, the atmosphere, the pathos. Through this contact, pathological states can then be actualized, assimilated and melt back into the background, in an awareness continuum (Yontef, 1993, p. 139).

The information written in the intake documents consists of reports of 'facts'. The therapist's reaction to the content of the client's documents is a feeling of dread. This feeling belongs to the therapist in isolation. The moment the therapist and client make contact, is the pre-formation of the contact. It is where the perceptive experience of the other is undifferentiated, diffused, and yet to emerge. The therapist describes a point where she, and perhaps the others of the field, finds herself seized by feelings of uneasiness of the yet unknown, and very-soon-to-be-experienced emerging convergence of fields.

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> '*I want to be confident, but something in my past is stopping me', Zaya translates.*

I give Ali a nod to acknowledge what I am hearing. He smiles back at me. His jacket hangs on a clothes rack by the door. This is the start of our second session.

Ali's opening sentence this morning feels like an invitation. Ali stands by a threshold between the future and the past. He points us in the direction of the past. I see him shudder. I shudder, though I do not know what it is I am seeing. I am interested, in earnest. I am also wary. I lean back.

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Field perspective of psychopathology

The client repeats his desire for moving on into the future, and says, '*but something in my past is stopping me*'. He repeats this in his first two sessions and several sessions thereafter. I tend to see the client's initial utterance as their attempt at being present with their pathos, making it palpable to the therapist. By responding to the pathos in the field (Francesetti, 2015), the therapist supports the emergence of the client's self, and his suffering in the field.

Responding to the sensed pathos in the field is potentially more useful to the therapist than a DSM (American Psychiatric Association, 2013) diagnosis. The diagnosis of PTSD written in the client's documents provided little for the therapist to use. A DSM diagnosis is mono-personal, relevant to the client in isolation, while the pathological field belongs to the client with the therapist in the situation of their encounter. The mono-personal approach to

diagnosis, a dominant paradigm of psychiatry and the DSM, focuses the treatment of symptoms experienced by the individual, while the bi-personal approach of relational modalities of psychotherapy affirms therapeutic change to arise through the therapeutic alliance (BCPSG, 2010; Clarkson, 2003; Greenberg, 1986; Jacobs & Hycner, 2009). Attunement to the aesthetics of the pathological field promises to expand the practitioner's reach even further. The field perspective challenges us to view psychotherapy as a convergence of the inter-subjective field of the therapist and the client and an emergence of a phenomenological (or pathological) field. Theory of the field is central to Gestalt therapy (Parlett, 1991; Philippson, 2009; Staemmler, 2006) as it is in psychology (Lewin, 1951). The field forms the holistic organization of the individuals of the therapeutic situation. The therapist, client, and translator find themselves in contact, and passively subjected to, the phenomenon of this field, which is characteristically emergent, unique, ephemeral, situated, co-created, corporeal, and dynamic.

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I ask Ali what he meant by the past stopping him from being confident.

'Uncle'. Ali explains that uncle is the younger brother of his father. Ali was put in the care of uncle and his wife when he was 9 years old. Till he turned 18, Ali lived with the couple and their daughter, who's a little younger than Ali. 'I always hear uncle say, "you will come to nothing. Nothing"'.

> 'What would you say to him right now, if he is sitting here?' I ask.
> Zaya translates.
> Ali clenches a fist, then promptly holds it down with the other hand. 'I have no words, nothing'.
> 'Yes'. I say. I give space to the young man's rage. Zaya reaches gingerly for a filled paper cup and takes a sip. Ali and I follow suit.
> I ask him how he got to be put in the care of uncle.

'After school I play football. The playground is near my house. One day, I was playing football, then the bomb of the Taliban exploded on our house'. Zaya translates this, ice cold. They were all home when it happened; Ali's father Zabi, his mother, Fatemeh and his baby sister Khatere. Ali's voice cracks as he mentions the name of his baby sister. He stares, glassy-eyed, blank.

The skin on the back of my neck tingles. I glance towards the radiator by the window, as if to check if it was turned on properly. No, the air in the room is not cold. I am being touched by phantoms who have now descended amongst us. I search my bag for paper, only to find a dog-eared stack of neon coloured post-its. I write, 'Zabi', 'Fatemeh', 'Khatere', on three little sheets, careful to get the spelling right. I lay the post-its on the coffee table. I feel tears well up in my eyes. The space between us is saturated.

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Creative indifference and the fertile void

Creative indifference is a term coined by German-Jewish philosopher and satirist, Salomo Friedländer (born 1871). The original German term for 'creative' is *schöpferische*, to 'create' in a way God creates, which is different from the meaning of having something made up. To be *indifferent*, refers to being intentionally disinterested, impartial, unbiased. It is important to qualify that being *disinterested* is the contrast of being *uninterested*, which is apathy. *Apathy* is the flattening of experience, the falling asleep to the pathos. Creative indifference embraces the possibility of diverse phenomena, that allows the therapist to be present to, and in contact with, the client's pathological field with open curiosity. In German, the term used by Friedländer is, *das Weltenschwangere Nichts*, which means literally, 'the nothingness that gives birth to worlds' (Frambach, 2003). This nothingness is also referred to as the fertile void.

There are many ways of explaining the concept of Creative Indifference. In this example, it is the virtue of patience, of taking time for the void of not-knowing to happen; by slowing down the conversation, by bringing attention to the emptiness of the space. In that space an uneasiness is felt by all. In holding this space, the therapist supports the client in sharing a wounded part of his childhood. All who were present experienced the pathos, the grief, that the client, at that moment, no longer was alone with.

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'How . . . are . . . you?' Ali asks me in English, then giggles.
'Thank you, Ali', I say. 'I slept well, so this morning you have my fullest attention'.
Zaya translates.
'How about you, Zaya', I ask.
I catch a slight blush in her cheeks, as she giggles, 'very well'.
'Ali says that he doesn't sleep well. For example last night he had a bad dream. A nightmare'. Zaya translates.

'There is the mafia', Ali says, 'who is raiding the castle. Me and my friends are hiding in it. The mafia shoots me. I'm almost dying and my friends save me. My father is there. Oh. But that is only for a short time. I fall out of the window and run away'.

We share a round of chuckling. I offer Ali and Zaya a suggestion to do a chair work. Zaya's eyes lights up. I'm aware that she had read much about the Gestalt therapy method of working with dreams. 'I'm not sure if you'd like to try this exercise'. I say to Ali, who is probably sensing Zaya's interest.

'Yes. Yes', is his reply.
'Well, if at any time either of you are feeling unwell doing this dreamwork, say stop'. I tell them.
'Yes. Yes', he says.
Zaya translates, 'What do I do?'

So we set the stage with empty chairs around us. I am thankful for having booked this larger room again this morning. Ali puts a chair for 'the mafia' a distant right from his. He then says that the rows of chairs stacked up along the wall of the room are where his friends sit. He takes the last chair and places it close behind him slightly to his left; there Ali seats his father.

*This is the dreamwork, abridged (see **Figure 1**)*

Interspersed within the dialogue is the translation process.

Therapist: 'We are all seated together in Ali's dream. The mafia sits on this chair to your right, and your father is sitting behind you to your left. Zaya and I are sitting in front of your friends. How is this for you?'

Ali: 'I don't want to talk to the mafia. The mafia is inhuman, does things that humans will not do'.

Therapist: 'What would you need to tell the mafia?'

Ali: 'To be more human'.

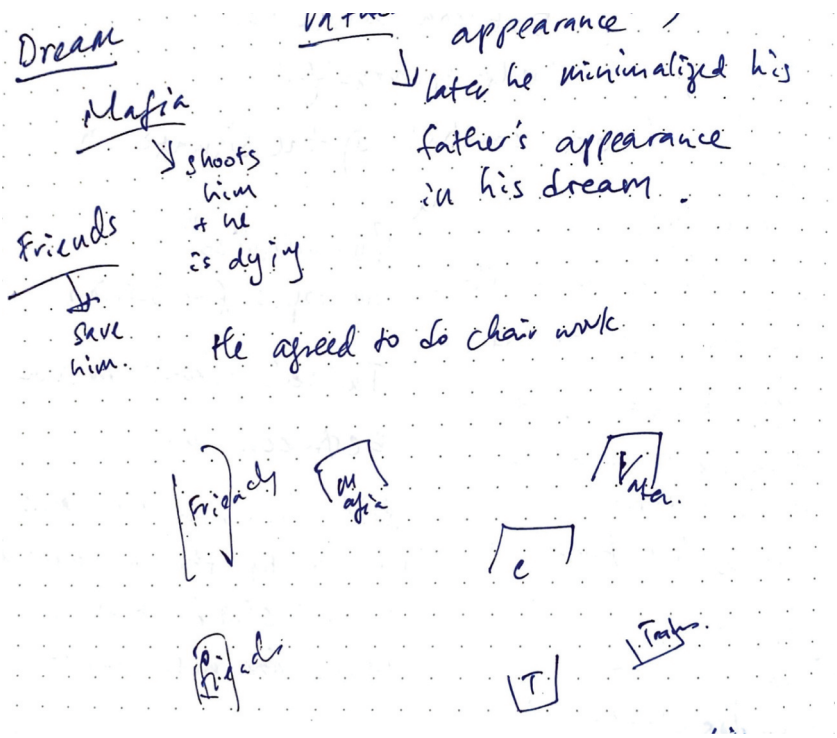

Figure 1. Excerpt from the therapist notes describing the dreamwork.

Therapist: 'How would the mafia answer to what you have just said?'

Ali shrugs.

I invite Ali to play the mafia, perhaps by sitting on the empty chair of the mafia.

Ali: 'No, no'.

Therapist: 'Then, should we ask the mafia to go away?'

Ali: 'No, no. Mafia can stay'.

Therapist: 'There is a chair behind you. Who sits there?'

Ali turns around, looks at the chair and turns back.

Ali: 'He was only there for a short while, in the beginning'.

Therapist: 'Your father. He was not there for very long'.

Ali: 'Yes'.

Therapist: 'How do you feel about your father sitting behind you?'

Ali: 'I feel good. But he's only here for a short time'.

Therapist: 'Yes'.

At this point, I would have liked to linger on with having a conversation with Ali's father, but I notice Ali's attention drift to the chair of the mafia. He turns to look at the chair of the mafia. I check with him what he was experiencing looking at that chair.

Ali: 'I am not so afraid of him (the mafia) now'.

Therapist: 'What has changed?'

Ali: 'My father is here'.

Ali shakes his head side-to-side, smiles and points to the chair, as if asking if it was okay that he moved to that chair now. He rises up and seats himself on the mafia's chair. That moment, I felt a tinge of sadness of seeing him move away from his father. My feelings seem to be in contrast, however, to Ali's mood. He has just motivated himself to move.

Ali (in the mafia's chair): 'Are you Ali's lawyer?'

Therapist: 'Not really. I'm with one of Ali's friends'.

Ali (in the mafia's chair): 'People don't understand that I come from a bad place where I have to do these things'.

I am aware that the session is almost up, and decide at this moment not to ask what 'these things' are.

Therapist to translator: 'I'm thinking that Ali looks a little different, sitting in this chair right now. What do you observe?'

Translator: 'Umm. A little. Umm. Yes'.

Therapist: 'What is different, do you reckon?'

Translator: 'Ali's no longer squeezing his hands together, he is sitting straight, he looks serious, not smiling as much'.

Time is up for the session. Ali says that he would like to stay in the mafia's chair till the end. 'It might help me with my school exams next week', Zaya translates.

We sit in this constellation for a while, in silence. Though not able to really grasp the meaning of this moment, I feel the lightness of gratitude.

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Gestalt therapy dreamwork

The above example is one of several methods of working with dreams in Gestalt therapy. This one is where the dream is acted out. In the dreamwork, the therapist brings the dream of the client into the space of the room with the use of empty chairs. The entire atmosphere is felt. From the work above, we observe how latent contents of the dream (Freud, 1899/1995), which are projected parts of the client's personality manifested as characters in the dream, are invited to show up in the therapy room.

> Freud once called the dream the Via Regia, the royal road to the unconscious. And I believe it is really the royal road to integration . . . The dream is the most spontaneous expression of the existence of the human being. (Perls, 1969/1992, p. 87)

***

The first sessions had set the aesthetics – the atmosphere – of the field, a meeting of three erstwhile (seemingly) discreet individuals, and the connecting of our phenomenological/pathological fields. Through the connection, we realize our own pathos; not only that of the client.

'My life is like the sea', says Ali six months into our work together, 'top is calm, underneath is in turmoil'. Ali uses this metaphor to impress on us how he yearns to be happy, but is haunted by the past, and that he is plagued by feelings of remorse for what he has done. He has also become aware of his feelings of envy towards the local citizens of Vienna. Being amongst the

privileged of this European city, he painfully reminds himself of how fate has robbed him of the dignified life that seems to belong so naturally to others.

Listening to Ali's articulate expression of his experience today – words that are still being translated to me by Zaya – I am filled with admiration. Not only for the client, but for everyone of us in this field. The Ali sitting in this room this morning looks very much an adult. He no longer wears his hair in tousled curls, having shaven them off 2 weeks ago. His face is also no longer smiley-cherubic, but sad and thoughtful. Lately, we share some words in German. This is the session where I am also painfully aware that our final session is near.

Zaya has tears in her eyes. I ask her if she's aware of an emotion she's feeling. 'Grief', she replies. I allow the word to settle upon us and give space for Zaya to compose herself, before moving on.

After the session ended, and we're both alone together, Zaya breaks down in tears. The pathos of this morning's session has filled her with deep feelings of grief. It was Ali's metaphor of the sea. She has, in recent months, lost two friends in separate situations to drowning – a schoolmate of her own child, and a good friend living in Iran, a young father of three – both violently swept away by currents beneath calm waters. I'm reminded of my friend, Ash. We sat together for a while. I couldn't contain my tears.

We gathered for nine months, three months longer than we had contracted to work together. In this field, a story and plot emerged. Ali's plot toggles between contents of his past and his future. From the former we hear of his suicide attempts, the violent treatment he endured from his uncle, the friends he had lost in the war. We hear of his concern for the women he had left behind in Afghanistan who had protected him – his uncle's wife, and the mother of his friend, also named Ali. We hear also of betrayal. Ali's future promises hope, despair, and uncertainty. What we had together was in the here-and-now, like a pivot, holding space in an undifferentiated situation.

Discussion

In working with disenfranchised groups, witnesses of oppression and violence, being present to their pain has far reaching effects on the much wider field. Violence is the transference of pain that is absent in the perpetrator to the victim. Pain is transferred until it is transformed (Weil, 1952). In the therapeutic encounter, that transformation can happen, transcending language and culture. This brings us full circle to the value of tuning in to aesthetics in psychotherapy research – through autoethnography – and practice – through attunement to the atmosphere of the field. *Aesthetics* is derived from the Greek origin of 'the sense of perception'. Contrast this with the *an-aesthetics* of medical science, and we may be able to appreciate the difference in the understanding of psychopathology and treatment of pain in

both fields. The client who is suffering usually describes themselves as being depressed, dissociated and numb. Psychopathological suffering is in essence an absence, rather than the pain itself (Francesetti, 2012). In the case story above, the client repeats that *something* in his past was keeping him from moving on. That *something* is a hint at the pathos. When the therapist becomes present to the client's pathos, they become present to suffering that was, till then, suffered alone by a nine-year-old child. This experience of being with the client, could have been missed had we settled with clinical diagnostics. The inquiry into the clients' suffering, is psychopathology that is an integral and effective part of the therapeutic process.

Current gaps in the field of psychotherapy research, according to Lutz et al. (2021, p. 11), involve the understanding of change processes in diverse, naturalistic psychotherapy environments, which remain ungraspable despite decades of quantitative, and even current qualitative research methods. This case study provides us the possibility to address the issue of communicating the aesthetic, and for the practitioner to contribute to this knowledge base. There is a heuristic aspect (Moustakas, 1990) of this process, a never-ending hermeneutic loop of understanding the therapeutic process and psychopathology. Using this research methodology alone, however, offers limited possibility of providing the objective and quantifiable data, which is still the predominant scientific paradigm.

Note

1. All the actors, and characters mentioned are given pseudonyms.

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